



at the public baths (*thermae*). Town baths were usually large buildings—the baths built in Rome by Emperor Caracalla had room for 1,600 visitors at a time!

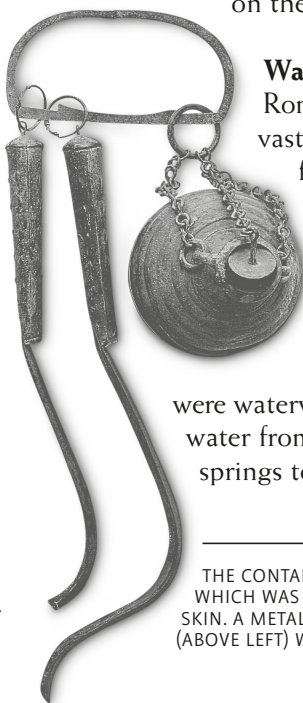
Men and women bathed at different times in small bathhouses and had separate areas in large public baths. Mixed bathing was not allowed. The layout of bathhouses suggest that Romans moved from cold to progressively hotter rooms, gradually acclimatizing their bodies. However, many bathers did not follow this plan. Some people would

begin by exercising to work up a sweat, while others would have a cold plunge bath.

Taking a bath was a social occasion, too—a chance to talk, gossip, and catch up on the news.

Water supply

Roman cities needed vast amounts of water for bathing, drinking, and washing waste away from their lavatories. Much of this was supplied by aqueducts. These were waterways that channeled water from rivers, lakes, and springs to built-up areas



THE CONTAINER ABOVE HELD OIL, WHICH WAS SPRINKLED ON A PERSON'S SKIN. A METAL SCRAPER CALLED A STRIGIL (ABOVE LEFT) WAS USED TO REMOVE IT.